Constructing the Nation: Identity and Historical Narratives in South Korean History Textbooks

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Abstract

How do the language and ideas of national identity in state-sanctioned educational material vary across regime types? We examine this question using 67 South Korean national history (*kuksa*) textbooks spanning 1895 to 2016. Large language models surface the identity-relevant terms in the corpus, and sentence-level embeddings let us follow how each term is used across five political regimes. We validate the language-model pipeline against BERTopic and Latent Dirichlet Allocation, confirming that the model recovers identity concepts no single conventional method captures on its own. A core post-liberation vocabulary of Korean nationhood stabilizes across both authoritarian and democratic textbooks. What changes across regimes is what each of these words is allowed to mean. Authoritarian schooling worked unevenly. It widened the meanings of *nation*, *independence*, and *citizens* around ethnic belonging and colonial grievance, while holding *community*, *society*, and *politics* to a narrower set of rote, formulaic uses. Democratization did not install a new official narrative in place of the inherited one. It widened the whole vocabulary again, returning room for plural and contested meanings across the board. Some of the meaning lost under authoritarian schooling did not fully return. The pattern is consistent with the view that political institutions shape not only which national story is told, but what the key words of that story are permitted to mean. A national vocabulary can be shared across regimes; the meanings those words carry can differ substantially with the institutions that produce them.

Keywords: national identity, history textbooks, Korean history, national language processing

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1 Introduction

How do the language and ideas defining a national identity in state-sanctioned educational material vary across regime types? Nations are not given. They are made, and mass education is one of the main instruments through which states make them (Anderson, 1983; Gellner, 1983; Hobsbawm, 1990). Existing scholarship links political institutions to the boundaries of national belonging and to the durability of national orientations across regime change (Darden & Grzymala-Busse, 2006; Wimmer, 2013). What we know less well is how regime type shapes the language of identity inside educational texts themselves. One common expectation is straightforward: authoritarian states impose a single story, while democratic institutions pluralize it. But the comparative literature gives less tidy guidance. Snyder (2000) argues that democratization can intensify nationalist mobilization when political competition expands faster than the institutions that restrain it. Jo (2025) shows that democratization also multiplies the elites who can contest, revise, or entrench the national story. The question is whether those institutional changes reach the most conservative sites of narrative production, or only the more flexible parts of the curriculum.

We examine that question through South Korean national history (*kuksa*, 국사) textbooks from the late nineteenth century to 2016. *Kuksa* occupies a distinctive place in the Korean curriculum. Social studies and ethics absorbed newer concerns such as multiculturalism, globalization, and civic participation (Moon, 2011; Watson, 2010). National history remained the curricular home of the master narrative: where the Korean nation came from, what ordeals it endured, and what political form it ought to inhabit (Kim & Kim, 2019; Shin, 2006). It is the discourse least likely to change. If political institutions reshape identity language even here, they reach the core of national self-understanding rather than its curricular margins.

The institutional history of *kuksa* makes this a strong test. The National Institute of Korean History (NIKH, 국사편찬위원회) was not only a certifying body. From 1974 to 2002, under the *kukchŏngje* (국정제, state-control) system, it wrote the single official textbook used

nationwide. The state did not merely screen competing manuscripts. It authored the text that students read. The policy rationale centered on unifying historical interpretation and countering perceived ideological division (Kim & Kim, 2019). The arrangement outlived Park Chung Hee, persisted through Chun Doo Hwan and the democratic transition, and only began to loosen in the 2000s (Kim & Kim, 2019; Seth, 2011). The 2015 attempt by the Park Geun-hye administration to restore the single-textbook system showed that the politics of *kuksa* remained unsettled long after formal democratization (Kim & Kim, 2019). We build on that institutional history by asking how the language of national identity changed across these regimes, not just which facts or events textbooks chose to emphasize.

The distinction between elite discourse and mass schooling matters here. During the colonial period, Korean intellectuals and cultural nationalists developed the language of *minjok* outside, and often against, the colonial education system (Em, 1999; Robinson, 1988; Schmid, 2002). Their work answered Japanese assimilationist claims with a counter-history of Korean distinctiveness (Caprio, 2009; Eckert, 1991). After liberation, the problem changed. The task was no longer to sustain a counter-narrative among intellectuals. It was to socialize an entire population through state-controlled schooling. Darden and Grzymala-Busse (2006) show that the first regime to achieve mass schooling can leave national orientations that endure well beyond the regime itself. The textbooks in our corpus are artifacts of that process. When identity terms appear in them, they record concepts selected for nationwide transmission rather than the preferences of a small scholarly public.

Most scholarship on Korean textbooks specifically relies on close reading, curriculum comparison, or smaller sets of editions (Lee, 2024; Ryu & Kim, 2022; Won & Huntington, 2021), though computational textbook analysis has advanced in other national contexts (Chen et al., 2023; Lucy et al., 2020). We take a computational approach to 67 textbooks spanning more than a century. We use large language models (LLMs) to discover identity-relevant terms directly from the corpus, then track their frequencies and sentence-level semantic shifts across periods. The main empirical result is not a simple move from authoritarian clo-

sure to democratic openness. A stable core vocabulary of nationhood establishes itself after liberation. Authoritarian schooling does not narrow this vocabulary uniformly. It widens the meanings of *nation*, *independence*, and *citizens* around ethnic belonging and colonial grievance, while holding concepts such as *community*, *society*, and *politics* to a narrower set of rote, formulaic uses. Democratization does not install a new official narrative in place of the inherited one. It widens all twelve identity terms again, returning room for plural and contested meanings without discarding the inherited core. What national identity means can differ markedly across regimes even when the vocabulary through which it is expressed is largely shared. The paper also offers a replicable framework for corpus-driven concept discovery, validated against BERTopic and Latent Dirichlet Allocation.

The next section reviews the literature on nationalism, education, and Korean history textbooks. We then describe the corpus and methods: LLM-based term discovery, normalized frequency analysis, and sentence-level semantic axes. The findings move from descriptive frequencies to the post-liberation semantic shifts that matter most for the argument. The discussion returns to the institutional question posed here and considers what the results imply for the study of nationalism and education.

2 National Identity, Education, and Institutions

Nations, boundaries, and the role of education

The starting point is simple. Nations are made. Anderson's account of imagined communities emphasized the role of shared narratives, symbols, and print forms in creating solidarity among people who will never meet (Anderson, 1983). Smith (1991) specified the institutional side of that process, tying national identity to common institutions, historical memory, public culture, rights, duties, and economic life (Smith, 1991, p. 14). Wimmer (2013) reframes the problem as one of boundary making. National identity depends on symbolic lines that define who counts as part of "we," on what grounds, and with what consequences. Those lines

are political. They shift with institutions, power relations, and the coalitions that control narrative production (Brubaker, 1996; Wimmer, 2018).

Mass schooling is one of the strongest mechanisms for drawing and stabilizing those boundaries. Gellner and Hobsbawm both treated standardized education as central to modern nationalism because it gives states a way to produce shared culture at scale (Gellner, 1983; Hobsbawm, 1990). Weber's account of nineteenth-century France showed the process in concrete terms: primary schools, language instruction, and patriotic history helped turn regionally rooted peasants into French citizens (Weber, 1976). The effects can last. Darden and Grzymala-Busse (2006) show that the national orientations formed under the first mass-schooling regime in a territory often persist through later regime changes. Nor does national reproduction end once a nation is established. Billig (1995) argues that nationhood is sustained through routine reminders that are easy to miss precisely because they are ordinary: flags, maps, pronouns, ceremonial forms, and the quiet repetition of "our" history.

Textbooks matter because they condense these processes into standardized form. They are the most portable version of what authorities want students to learn. Studies of political socialization show that children form durable orientations toward authority, community, and nationhood early in life (Easton & Hess, 1962; Jennings & Niemi, 1974). Textbooks therefore offer unusually direct access to official narrative. They also record what Apple (1993) calls "official knowledge": the version of the past and the polity that a state chooses to authorize for transmission. That is true in democracies as well as authoritarian systems, though the institutional filters differ. Recent cross-national work sharpens the point for authoritarian settings. Tetteh and Edgell (2026) show that educational indoctrination is associated with weaker pro-democracy mobilization, fewer anti-system campaigns, and greater regime-compatible mobilization. Schooling can widen political horizons, but it can also narrow them.

Regime type, institutions, and the grand narrative

Regime type matters, but not in a mechanical way. Authoritarian rule does not always yield a rigid nationalist discourse, and democracy does not always dissolve it into pluralism. Snyder (2000) shows that incomplete democratization can intensify nationalist appeals because elites in new competitive settings have incentives to mobilize through identity rather than program. Mylonas (2012) makes a related point from a different angle: state nation-building strategies depend on geopolitical alignment as well as domestic institutions. Wimmer (2018) likewise argues that nation-building depends on broader configurations of alliance, communication, and state capacity rather than on regime type alone.

For this paper, the key question is therefore not whether democracy changes the grand narrative, but how institutional change reaches it. Jo (2025) offers the most useful account. Democratization empowers "storytelling elites," actors who have the authority and capacity to define the nation in public discourse. In South Korea, Jo argues, democratic contestation did not displace the ethnonationalist "One Korea" frame. It entrenched it. Taiwan followed a different path. There, curriculum reform and democratic opening helped displace "One China" with a more civic and territorial Taiwanese identity (Chen et al., 2023; Ho, 2022). The contrast matters for our case. Democratic institutions may preserve the core narrative while widening the range of concepts, contexts, and arguments through which it is expressed.

That is the possibility we test. We are not asking whether South Korean textbooks became "more democratic" in the abstract. We ask whether the language of national identity changed as the institutions that produced textbooks changed. By focusing on *kuksa*, we make the test difficult on purpose. If political transitions reshape identity language in the most conservative domain of the curriculum, the effect is hard to dismiss as noise from more flexible subjects such as social studies or ethics (Ahn, 2012; Moon, 2011).

Korean history education and the politics of *kuksa*

South Korea is unusually well suited to this question because regime change and textbook politics are compressed into a single national setting. The modern textbook tradition dates to the Kabo reforms of 1894–95, when the new education apparatus began to standardize history instruction for schools (Seth, 2011; Wells, 1999). Under Japanese colonial rule, Korean history was subordinated to imperial priorities, excised from some curricular spaces, and rewritten in others (Caprio, 2009). During this period, nationalism survived largely through intellectual and associational work rather than through mass public education. Writers such as Sin Ch'aeho helped develop *minjok* as a modern historical subject, but that language circulated among educated publics, not through a sovereign Korean school system (Em, 1999, 2013; Robinson, 1988; Schmid, 2002).

After 1945, history education became part of a mass nation-building project. Postwar textbooks trained students to understand the republic through anti-colonial memory, anti-communism, and patriotic duty (Seth, 2002; Sorensen, 1994). The shift to *kukchŏngje* in 1973–74 intensified that project. Once NIKH became the direct author of the national history textbook, the state could standardize narrative at the level of wording as well as content. Those textbooks promoted a purified *minjok* narrative, militant anti-communism, and a legitimating history of the authoritarian state, including the reframing of the 1961 coup as a "revolution" (Kim & Kim, 2019; Shin, 2006). The system remained in place through the Fifth National Curriculum, well after the formal democratic transition had begun.

Democratization loosened that monopoly, but it did not make *kuksa* politically neutral. Modern and contemporary Korean history moved to authorization in 2002, and the broader shift from state authorship to certification opened space for privately produced textbooks with more varied emphases (Seth, 2011). Even so, national history remained a high-stakes arena. The 2015 push to restore a single state-authored textbook provoked opposition from Korean historians and international scholars alike before collapsing with the Park Geun-hye administration (Kim & Kim, 2019). Other parts of the curriculum changed earlier and more

visibly. *Kuksa* remained the place where the nation narrated itself in its most formal voice.

Comparative work on Korean textbooks reinforces the point. North and South Korea produced rival versions of "Koreanness" within a shared ethnic frame, one tied to democratic legitimacy and global integration, the other to revolutionary struggle and dynastic rule (Jager, 2003; Won & Huntington, 2021). Shin et al. (1999) describe this as the paradox of divided Korea: shared ethnicity sustains a common language of nationhood even as each state reworks it for its own legitimacy. Comparative textbook studies beyond Korea show the same basic pattern. States do not simply recount the past. They organize it around preferred lines of pride, grievance, and belonging (Lin et al., 2009; Ryu & Kim, 2022). Related survey-experimental work involving one of the present authors points in the same direction: identity conformity pressures are stronger in South Korea, consistent with the long reach of uniform state narratives in education (Denney et al., 2026).

That institutional and comparative context gives the paper its leverage. If the vocabulary of national identity changes in *kuksa*, it changes in the part of the curriculum designed to resist change. That is why these textbooks provide a hard test of the relationship between political institutions and national narrative.

3 Data

Rationale and scope

We study the construction of state-directed national identity through a corpus of officially disseminated Korean history textbooks. The corpus draws on two sources. The first is the National Institute of Korean History (NIKH, 국사편찬위원회) digital archive, especially the *Yŏktae Kuksa Kyogwasŏ* collection, which provides digitized textbooks from the late nineteenth century through the early 2000s. The second is a set of scanned PDFs from the Georg Eckert Institute for International Textbook Research (GEI), which extends coverage into later democratic-era publications.

The GEI books were processed with DeepSeek-OCR, a 3-billion-parameter vision-language model designed for document OCR. The model preserves basic document structure, including headings, lists, and tables, while producing machine-readable markdown. We ran it on GPU infrastructure with flash attention at 200–300 DPI, then cleaned the output to remove residual HTML, repeated characters, decorative symbols, and LaTeX debris. Across the 16 GEI textbooks, this post-processing reduced character-level noise by 23.3% while preserving substantive text.

The merged corpus contains 67 textbooks: 51 from NIKH and 16 from GEI. It spans the Kabo reforms and Korean Empire, the colonial period, the U.S. military government and early republic, the state-authored textbook era, and the democratic transition through 2016. This long horizon lets us separate two questions that are often conflated. One is historical rupture, especially the break between colonial and post-liberation discourse. The other is variation within the post-liberation tradition as textbook production moved across postwar, authoritarian, and democratic institutions.

Data model and harmonization

The analysis file stores one row per textbook. Each row contains a stable identifier (`book_id`), title, curriculum label, five-period classification, school level, publisher, year, section and page counts, and two text fields. `full_text` contains the textbook as continuous natural prose and is the input to both the LLM term-discovery pipeline and the sentence-level embedding analysis. `processed_text` contains a noun-focused derivative (see below) used for token-based frequency counts.

Metadata required harmonization because titles, series labels, and edition markers vary across printings. We normalized recurring markers such as *kwŏn* (권, volume), *sang/ha* (상·하, upper/lower), and reprint notes so that minor typographic variation did not create artificial duplicates. Where metadata were incomplete, we reconciled titles and curriculum windows against the merged corpus and retained the most stable bibliographic form avail-

able. All text was stored in normalized Unicode (NFC) with stray whitespace and zero-width characters removed.

The `processed_text` field improves comparability across decades for count-based analysis, because Korean particles and inflection generate many surface forms for the same concept and inflate noise when raw text is counted. Using KiwiPiePy, we retained common and proper nouns (NNG, NNP), merged compound nouns, and excluded numerals, punctuation-like tokens, and single-syllable items unless recognized as proper nouns. Term-frequency analysis runs over this cleaned stream. By contrast, the LLM term-discovery pipeline and the sentence-embedding pipeline both operate on `full_text` directly, so models see natural prose rather than a decontextualized noun bag.

For descriptive analysis, we collapse the corpus into five historically grounded periods: Late Chosŏn, Colonial, Postwar, Authoritarian, and Democratic. This periodization is fixed and reversible. It preserves the major political distinctions relevant to the paper while keeping the dataset large enough for comparison across periods and school levels. The frequency analysis uses all five periods. The semantic-axis analysis then narrows to the two post-liberation transitions, because the Colonial→Postwar rupture reflects a change between discourse systems rather than a within-tradition adjustment. Appendix F in the Supplementary Information reports the full-timeline robustness check behind that decision.

Period	Years	Representative titles	School levels	N
Late Chosŏn	1895–1910	*Chosŏn yŏksa* (조선역사); *Chosŏn yŏktae saryak* (조선역대사략); *Tongguk yŏksa* / *Tongguk saryak* series	Elem / MS / HS	14
Colonial	1910–1945	*Simsang sohakkyo kuksa poch'ung* series (심상소학교 국사보충); teacher and pupil supplements issued under colonial authority	Elem / Supp.	4
Postwar	1945–1972	*Kuksa kyobon* (국사교본); 1st- and 2nd-curriculum middle and high school *kuksa*; elementary social studies volumes with national history content	Elem / MS / HS	8
Authoritarian	1973–1993	3rd-, 4th-, and 5th-curriculum *kuksa* textbooks; *National Education Charter* era texts; state-authored elementary, middle, and high school volumes	Elem / MS / HS	19
Democratic	1993–2016	6th- and 7th-curriculum *kuksa*; privately published *Han'guk kŭnhyŏndaesa* (한국근현대사); revised *Han'guksa* (한국사)	Elem / MS / HS	22
Total	**1895–2016**			**67**

Table 1: Coverage of the textbook corpus by period.
Note: Period labels follow the regime-oriented periodization used in the main text. Representative titles are illustrative rather than exhaustive. The merged corpus contains 51 NIKH textbooks and 16 GEI textbooks processed via OCR.

Texts and metadata are distributed as `nikh_corpus_merged.csv` and `nikh_corpus.parquet`. The merged analysis file contains textbook identifiers, standardized metadata, and both text fields used in the paper.

Institutional context and analytical implications

The corpus was produced under sharply different institutional arrangements. From 1945 through 1973, South Korea used a *kŏmjŏngje* (검정제, authorization) system in which multiple private publishers could produce textbooks subject to state approval. The state still set boundaries, but more than one authorial voice could appear in print. In 1973–74, the Park Chung Hee government replaced that system with full *kukchŏngje* (국정제, state control). The reform was justified as a way to unify historical interpretation and counter ideological division (Kim & Kim, 2019). Under the new arrangement, NIKH became the direct author of the national history textbook.

That distinction matters for interpretation. Textbooks produced under *kukchŏngje* are best read as direct state speech. They reflect what the regime sought to teach at scale, not an aggregate of independent scholarly judgments. Studies of the 1974 textbooks show how far that intervention reached: the books described the 1961 coup as a "revolution" by "patriotic soldiers" and removed inconvenient promises to return power to civilians (Kim & Kim, 2019). By contrast, textbooks from the democratic period were still certified by the state, but they were produced by independent publishers and author teams. Variation across books becomes meaningful in a different way because it can register broader historiographical and political disagreement.

This institutional contrast guides the analysis throughout. When a term expands or contracts under authoritarianism, the shift reflects changes within a tightly centralized production system. When the same term changes under democracy, the shift may reflect curricular reform, publisher choice, scholarly debate, or public discourse filtered through certification. The point is not that one period is controlled and the other is free. It is that the mecha-

nisms of textual production differ, and those differences should be visible in the language of identity.

4 Methods

Term discovery

A central problem in studying national identity is deciding which concepts to track. Rather than start from a hand-built keyword list, we used a corpus-driven discovery pipeline based on large language models (LLMs). The pipeline has three stages: extraction, validation and scoring, and cross-model consensus.

For extraction, we prompted three EXAONE models from the same family, at 2.4B, 7.8B, and 32B quantized parameters, to identify nouns and noun phrases related to national identity in `full_text` windows drawn from each textbook (LG AI Research, 2024). Windows were 4,000 characters long. Each book contributed between 3 and 50 windows, scaled to document length, sampled under a fixed random seed. Sampling always included the beginning, middle, and end of a book before drawing additional windows from the interior. The Korean prompt asked for identity-relevant vocabulary tied to collective belonging, nation and ethnicity, state and territory, unification and independence, democracy and political order, and historical legitimacy. The full prompt appears in Appendix D of the Supplementary Information.

We reduced raw outputs to root nouns with KiwiPiePy. For each extracted phrase, the longest noun token tagged as NNG or NNP was retained. This collapses inflected or multi-morpheme expressions onto a common lexical root before scoring.

Validation and scoring proceeded in three steps. First, each candidate term was checked for semantic grounding by embedding the term and its source window with `paraphrase-multilingual-MiniLM-L12-v2` and computing cosine similarity. Second, we filtered likely hallucinations by requiring at least three exact matches in the full corpus. Third, we com-

puted a weighted score for each term: 40% normalized corpus frequency and 60% normalized semantic similarity. The heavier weight on similarity reduces the chance that frequent but generic nouns dominate the final list.

Finally, we imposed cross-model consensus. A term entered the final set if (i) at least two of the three EXAONE models selected it *and* (ii) the mean weighted frequency across the models that selected it exceeded 300. Twelve identity terms survive both filters: *kongdongch'e* (공동체, community), *kukka* (국가, state), *kungmin* (국민, citizen), *tongnip* (독립, independence), *minjok* (민족, nation/ethnos), *minjujuŭi* (민주주의, democracy), *sahoe* (사회, society),[1] *yŏksa* (역사, history), *yŏngt'o* (영토, territory), *chŏngch'i* (정치, politics), *t'ongil* (통일, unification), and *haebang* (해방, liberation).

We validated this list against BERTopic and Latent Dirichlet Allocation. BERTopic recovered all twelve terms and LDA recovered seven. Appendix A of the Supplementary Information reports specifications and recovery rates in full. For present purposes, the important point is modest: the final list is recoverable from the corpus by independent methods, even though no single conventional model reproduces it on its own. Appendix H reports a separate robustness rerun of the full three-model pipeline on `full_text` rather than on noun-filtered `processed_text`, which supports the same set of terms (eleven of twelve entering unchanged; *sahoe* retained as just described).

Frequency analysis

We begin with exact term counts. For each textbook, we count occurrences of the twelve target terms in `processed_text` and normalize by the total number of tokens in that book, reporting mean frequency per 1,000 tokens. This controls for large differences in textbook length across periods and school levels. Frequencies are then aggregated by period and, in Appendix E of the Supplementary Information, by period crossed with school level.

[1] *Sahoe* (사회) crosses the cross-model threshold but sits below the frequency threshold under full-text extraction (mean 186.2). It enters the final set on the strength of the earlier `processed_text` consensus run (mean 328.3), coherent recovery in BERTopic and LDA topic models, and qualitative centrality to the civic-national cluster. Appendix H reports the side-by-side comparison and full justification.

Sentence embeddings and semantic axes

Frequency tells us which terms rise or fall. It does not tell us whether a term is being used in a wider range of contexts, in a narrower one, or in a new part of the semantic field. To address that problem, we split `full_text` into sentences with Kiwi and embed every sentence containing one of the twelve keywords with `BM-K/KoSimCSE-roberta-multitask`. The result is a sentence-level embedding space in which shifts in contextual usage can be measured directly. The approach builds on work using diachronic embeddings to track semantic change (Hamilton et al., 2016), cultural dimensions (Kozlowski et al., 2019), and the shifting meanings of political concepts (Rodman, 2020).

We use three complementary axes. For each transition, we fit a separate logistic regression classifier per term to capture discriminability: how strongly sentences containing that term separate adjacent periods. The contrastive PCA axis (Abid et al., 2018) captures changes in contextual spread: whether a term's usage expands or contracts across periods. The Procrustes axis captures residual repositioning after the two embedding clouds are optimally aligned, following the alignment procedure introduced by Hamilton et al. (2016) for diachronic word vectors and adapted here for sentence-level embeddings. Together, these axes distinguish three different forms of change: period-specific reframing, expansion or compression of contextual range, and geometric relocation within the larger vocabulary of identity. The results section introduces the axes in substantive terms and interprets them with concrete examples.

5 Results

The vocabulary of nationhood

Before turning to semantic change, it is useful to establish when the vocabulary of modern Korean nationhood entered the textbook corpus. Figure 1 reports mean frequency per 1,000

tokens for the 12 identity terms across the five historical periods. The dominant pattern is the rupture at liberation. In the Late Chosŏn and Colonial periods, most of the terms that later anchor postcolonial identity discourse are either absent or marginal. *Minjok* (민족, nation) appears only rarely in Late Chosŏn textbooks and not at all in Colonial ones. *Kungmin* (국민, citizen) is similarly sparse before liberation. *Minjujuŭi* (민주주의, democracy) and *kongdongch'e* (공동체, community) are absent from both periods, and *haebang* (해방, liberation) is effectively absent as well. The modern lexicon of Korean nationhood had not yet cohered in school history.

The Postwar period marks the construction of this vocabulary in public education. With liberation and the establishment of the Republic, textbooks introduced a coordinated language of politics, citizenship, society, and nationhood. *Chŏngch'i* (정치, politics), *minjok* (민족, nation), *sahoe* (사회, society), *kukka* (국가, state), and *kungmin* (국민, citizen) all appear at substantial frequencies, while *minjujuŭi* enters the corpus for the first time. History textbooks became one of the main channels through which the postcolonial state gave students a vocabulary for nation, state, and political community.

Two pre-liberation terms stand out as exceptions. *Yŏngt'o* (영토, territory) peaks in the Colonial period, when Japanese imperial historiography foregrounded territorial questions. *T'ongil* (통일, unification) also appears before liberation, but in reference to historical consolidation, above all Unified Silla, rather than to the modern problem of national division. Both terms remain in the post-liberation corpus, but their semantic role changes substantially.

The Authoritarian and Democratic periods then reweight this postwar vocabulary in revealing ways. *Minjok* reaches its highest frequency under authoritarianism, consistent with the regime's investment in ethnic nationalism as a source of legitimacy. *Sahoe* and *kukka* also peak in this period. *Tongnip* (독립, independence) rises steadily across the three postwar periods, while *minjujuŭi* is most frequent in the early postwar era and declines thereafter. This frequency profile sets the stage for the semantic analysis. The vocabulary of Korean nationhood was assembled above all after liberation, and its internal balance changed across

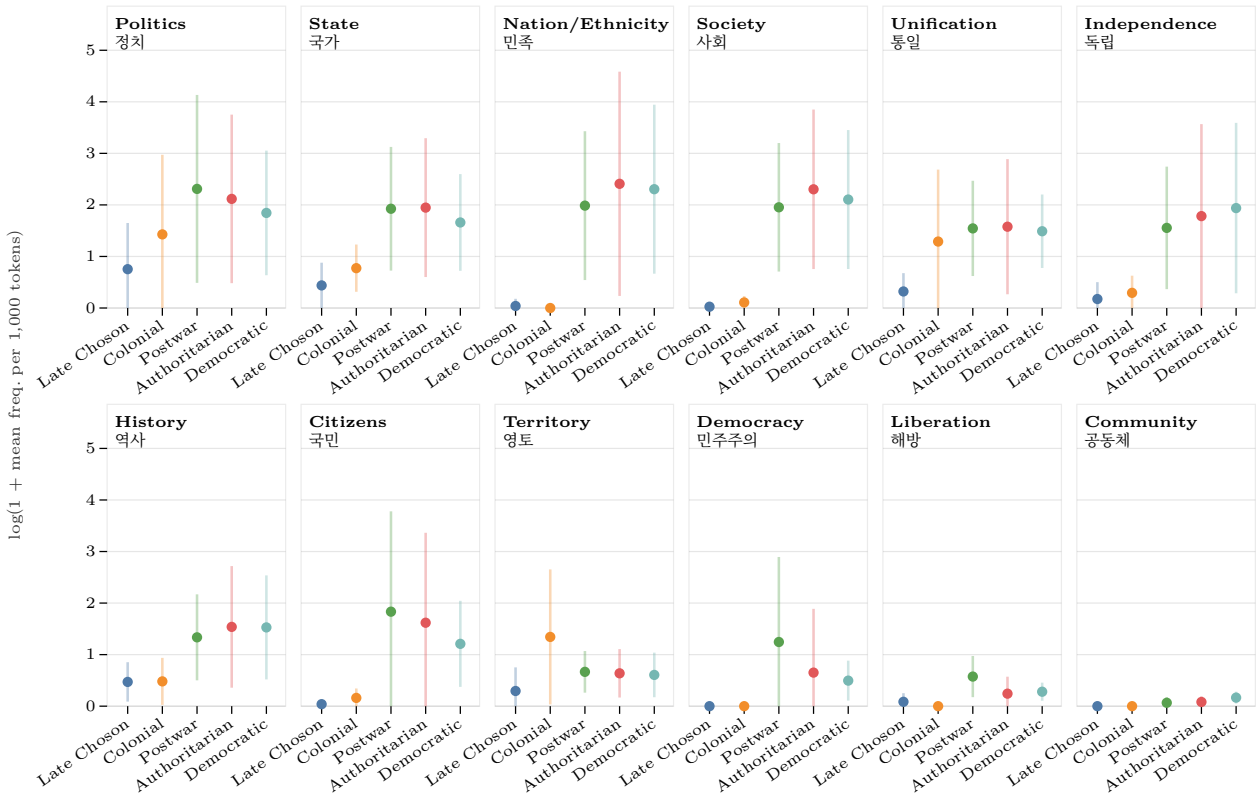

Figure 1: Mean frequency per 1,000 tokens for 12 identity terms across five historical periods. Error bars indicate one standard deviation across textbooks within each period.

regimes. Frequency alone cannot tell us whether terms changed in meaning, whether their semantic range widened or narrowed, or how their position relative to one another shifted. For that, we turn to sentence-level semantic analysis.

The liberation rupture and the scope of the analysis

An initial full-timeline analysis examined twelve identity terms across five periods, from the Late Chosŏn era to the contemporary democratic period. This preliminary comparison showed that the Colonial to Postwar transition produced semantic-axis shifts averaging 1.97, roughly 2.3 times larger than any subsequent transition. By contrast, the Postwar to Authoritarian and Authoritarian to Democratic transitions yielded mean deltas of 0.71 and 0.87 respectively.

The difference in magnitude marks the boundary of a continuous discourse tradition. Late Chosŏn textbooks remained grounded in dynastic and neo-Confucian historiography. Colonial textbooks were shaped by Japanese imperial narratives and censorship. Post-liberation textbooks belong to a nationalist-republican discourse of history education with little continuity with the colonial one, built around a shared postcolonial horizon: the independence movement, liberation, the division of the peninsula, and the task of educating citizens of a Korean state. The liberation rupture therefore marks a shift between discourse systems, while the semantic changes within the post-liberation sequence represent transformations within an ongoing framework. The rupture is best understood as the historical precondition for the later dynamics of selective appropriation, freezing, expansion, and recovery: a new set of institutional actors gained control of the textbook apparatus in 1945, creating the institutional environment in which later regimes reshaped identity discourse. The remainder of the analysis focuses on the two post-liberation transitions, Postwar to Authoritarian and Authoritarian to Democratic.

Aggregate patterns across post-liberation transitions

The focused analysis examines semantic shifts in twelve identity terms across two major political transitions in post-liberation Korean history. Following the structure of national curriculum cycles, textbooks were grouped into three macro-periods: *Postwar* (first and second national curricula, 1945–1972, 8 textbooks), *Authoritarian* (third through fifth curricula, 1973–1993, 19 textbooks), and *Democratic* (sixth and seventh curricula, 1993–2016, 22 textbooks). These macro-periods each contain distinct sub-regimes and curriculum cycles, and the aggregation smooths over that internal variation. For each term and transition, we compute three complementary semantic axes: a logistic regression axis (LR), which captures discriminability between periods, a contrastive variance axis based on cPCA, and an alignment residual axis based on Procrustes analysis (PA). Table 2 reports the complete results.

Table 2: Semantic shift values for twelve identity terms across two transitions and three axes. LR = logistic regression (discriminative). cPCA = contrastive PCA (variance). PA = Procrustes analysis (alignment residual). Values represent signed shift magnitudes in standard deviation units along each axis.

	Postwar → Authoritarian			**Authoritarian → Democratic**		
Term	LR	cPCA	PA	LR	cPCA	PA
Independence (독립)	−0.46	2.83	0.05	0.39	2.10	0.32
Nation (민족)	−0.46	1.74	−0.63	0.40	1.22	0.38
Unification (통일)	−0.41	0.32	−0.16	0.48	2.86	0.04
History (역사)	−0.45	1.49	−0.58	0.45	2.17	0.49
Democracy (민주주의)	−0.40	0.52	0.31	0.50	1.58	0.29
Citizens (국민)	−0.47	1.59	−0.43	0.45	1.48	−0.41
State (국가)	−0.47	−0.85	−0.36	0.33	1.30	−0.21
Politics (정치)	−0.50	−0.89	−0.19	0.33	0.85	0.06
Society (사회)	−0.45	−1.18	−0.21	0.37	0.76	−0.18
Territory (영토)	−0.49	−0.18	−0.37	0.34	1.34	0.02
Liberation (해방)	−0.42	−1.98	−0.15	0.41	1.08	1.91
Community (공동체)	−0.47	−2.89	−0.26	0.49	5.00	−0.47
Mean	−0.45	0.04	−0.25	0.41	1.81	0.19
Mean (absolute)	0.46	1.37	0.31	0.41	1.81	0.40

At the aggregate level, the two post-liberation transitions are comparable in overall magnitude. Across all term-axis combinations, the Postwar to Authoritarian transition produced

shifts averaging 0.71 with a median of 0.46, while the Authoritarian to Democratic transition yielded shifts averaging 0.87 with a median of 0.46. That similarity conceals important internal differences: regime change did not affect all concepts equally, nor did it operate through a single mechanism.

The clearest pattern emerges when the results are disaggregated by axis. As Table 3 shows, the contrastive variance axis consistently produces larger shifts than either the discriminative or the alignment residual axis.

Table 3: Mean absolute shift magnitudes by axis and transition. The contrastive variance axis (cPCA) consistently produces shifts three to five times larger than the discriminative and alignment residual axes.

Axis	**Postwar → Auth.**	**Auth. → Dem.**
Discriminative (LR)	0.46	0.41
Contrastive variance (cPCA)	1.37	1.81
Alignment residual (PA)	0.31	0.40

During the Postwar to Authoritarian transition, variance shifts average 1.37, compared to 0.46 on the discriminative axis and 0.31 on the alignment residual axis. The pattern intensifies during the Authoritarian to Democratic transition, where variance shifts average 1.81 compared to 0.41 and 0.40 respectively. Of the fifteen largest individual shifts in the entire analysis, fourteen fall on the variance axis. The sole exception is the Procrustes shift for *haebang* (해방, liberation) during democratization, whose polysemy-driven repositioning (discussed in section 5) reaches a magnitude otherwise found only on the variance axis. The dominant mode of semantic change was therefore not wholesale replacement of one vocabulary by another, but expansion or contraction in the range of contexts in which terms could appear. Terms acquired new discursive environments, shed old ones, or were held within a narrow range of acceptable uses, while often retaining continuity at the level of core reference.

To test whether transitions produced coherent change or only scattered term-specific

drifts, we fit a separate logistic classifier for each of the twelve terms. If regime change altered only a few concepts, some classifiers would separate periods while others would perform at chance. In fact, all twelve classifiers separate their two periods above the balanced-prediction baseline (0.50), with five-fold cross-validated accuracy averaging 0.71 for the Postwar to Authoritarian transition and 0.73 for the Authoritarian to Democratic transition.[2] Figure 2 plots the per-term CV accuracies for both transitions. More important than accuracy is directionality: every centroid shifts in the same direction, toward the later period, in all twelve cases and in both transitions. This unanimity is not guaranteed by the method, since each classifier operates on a different set of sentences with its own axis. That every term individually tracks the same period boundary indicates a systemic change in textbook language rather than isolated lexical shifts.

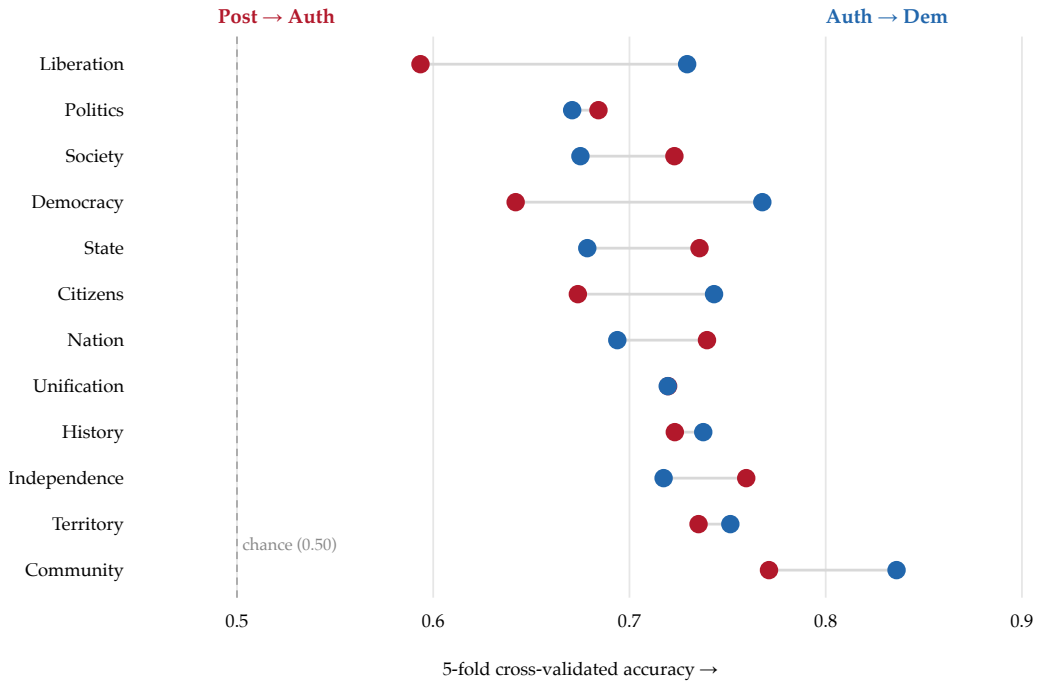

Figure 2: Per-term 5-fold cross-validated accuracy for logistic classifiers distinguishing adjacent periods, one classifier per term. All twenty-four classifiers (12 terms × 2 transitions) separate their two periods above the balanced-prediction baseline of 0.50. Terms are ordered by their mean accuracy across the two transitions.

[2]Sentence counts per term per period range from 9 (*kongdongch'e*, Postwar) to 5,298 (*minjok*, Democratic). Terms with 100 or fewer Postwar-period sentences (*kongdongch'e*, *haebang*, *yŏngt'o*) should be interpreted cautiously.

Table 4 summarizes the direction and consistency of shifts across all three axes.

Table 4: Shift consistency across axes and transitions. The discriminative axis was computed per-term (12 separate classifiers). Variance and alignment residual axes were computed on pooled sentences and then projected per-term. Discriminative accuracy reports the range of per-term classification accuracy.

	Post. → Auth.		**Auth. → Dem.**	
Axis	Direction	Accuracy	Direction	Accuracy
Discriminative (per-term LR)	12/12	0.59–0.77	12/12	0.67–0.84
Variance (cPCA)	6+ / 6−	—	12+ / 0−	—
Alignment residual (PA)	2+ / 10−	—	8+ / 4−	—

More important for the argument is the variance axis (Figure 3). During the Postwar to Authoritarian transition, six terms expand while six compress, an even split that bootstrap resampling confirms as stable (200 iterations produce the same grouping). During the Authoritarian to Democratic transition, all twelve terms expand without exception. The contrast between selective appropriation and universal expansion is the main empirical difference between the two transitions.

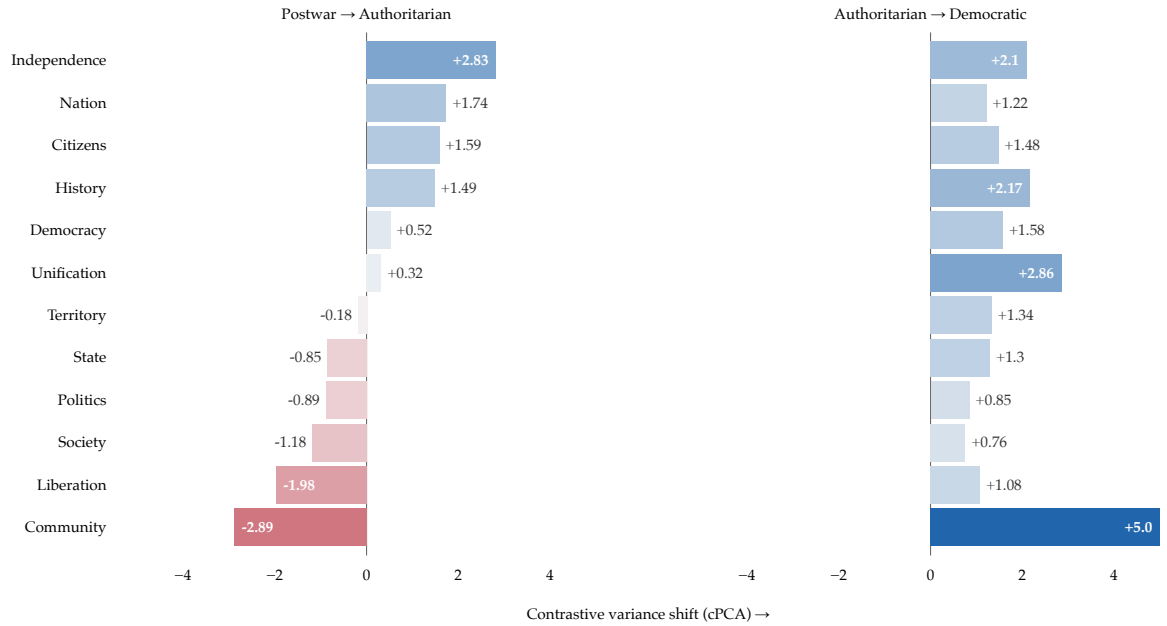

Figure 3: Contrastive variance shifts (cPCA) for twelve identity terms across two post-liberation transitions. Left panel: Postwar to Authoritarian. Right panel: Authoritarian to Democratic. During authoritarian consolidation, six terms expand while six compress. During democratization, all twelve expand. Terms are ordered by their signed Postwar-to-Authoritarian shift, from largest expansion at the top to largest compression at the bottom.

Selective appropriation under authoritarianism

The Postwar to Authoritarian transition is marked above all by unevenness. Authoritarian consolidation did not reshape educational discourse uniformly. Instead, it expanded semantic space around concepts useful for nationalist legitimation while compressing the range of terms associated with political and social analysis. Table 5 groups terms by the direction of their variance shift.

Table 5: Contrastive variance shifts during authoritarian consolidation, grouped by direction. The regime expanded discourse around national identity concepts while compressing political and social terminology.

Pattern	**Term**	**Variance shift**
Expansion	Independence (독립)	+2.83
	Nation (민족)	+1.74
	Citizens (국민)	+1.59
	History (역사)	+1.49
	Democracy (민주주의)	+0.52
	Unification (통일)	+0.32
Compression	Territory (영토)	−0.18
	State (국가)	−0.85
	Politics (정치)	−0.89
	Society (사회)	−1.18
	Liberation (해방)	−1.98
	Community (공동체)	−2.89

Three expanding terms stand out: *tongnip* (독립, independence), *minjok* (민족, nation), and *kungmin* (국민, citizens). These concepts underwent the largest expansions during authoritarian consolidation, consistent with a regime investing in anti-colonial legitimacy, ethnic-national belonging, and disciplined citizenship. *Yŏksa* (역사, history) also expanded strongly. Among the six compressed terms, *haebang* (해방, liberation) undergoes the second-largest compression (−1.98), while *kukka* (국가, state), *chŏngch'i* (정치, politics), and *sahoe* (사회, society) cluster in the middle. *Yŏngt'o* (영토, territory) contracts only slightly (−0.18). *Kongdongch'e*'s nominally large compression (−2.89) rests on only 9 Postwar sentences, most repeating a single phrase, and is unreliable as a measure of semantic range. Even setting it aside, the pattern is clear: the regime narrowed vocabulary associated with liberation, political structure, and social analysis while expanding vocabulary associated with ethnic-

national identity. The compression of *haebang* is consistent with the liberation narrative being channeled into a fixed commemorative register.

This pattern is best understood as selective appropriation. Authoritarian rule did not compress the discourse uniformly. It widened the semantic field of concepts that could support regime legitimacy and narrowed the field of concepts through which political or social analysis might become more open-ended. The institutional mechanism was *kukchŏngje* (국정제), the state-authored textbook system, which gave the regime direct editorial authority over the language of history education. *Tongnip* expanded from armed anti-colonial struggle into broader narratives of reform, sovereignty, and institutional nation-building. *Kungmin* developed new associations with state-directed citizenship, above all through repeated invocations of the *National Education Charter*. *Minjok* is the clearest case of this broader process.

Minjok followed a parallel but more consequential trajectory. Its variance shift of $+1.74$ indicates substantial semantic expansion, while its alignment residual of -0.63, the largest such movement in the Postwar to Authoritarian transition, shows that this expansion was accompanied by structural repositioning within the conceptual field, consistent with reorganization around authoritarian legitimation. Postwar textbooks often framed nation in a relatively abstract pedagogical register, linking national history to patriotism, self-reflection, and moral cultivation. Authoritarian-era textbooks retained that didactic function but extended the term into a broader discourse of colonial victimization, ethnic continuity, and historical grievance. The result was a heavier ideological load. Criticism of Japanese colonial oppression and celebration of national endurance now appeared in contexts that aligned with postcolonial state legitimation.

A brief comparison illustrates the shift, drawn from the extreme sentences on the contrastive axis. Postwar textbooks typically framed *minjok* in an abstract pedagogical register:

> 국사 교육은 우리 민족의 과거 생활을 정확하게 인식시켜 자아를 반성하고 애국심과 자주 정신을 함양하는데 중요한 의의와 목적이 있는 것이다.
>
> "*National history education has important significance and purpose in accurately rec-*

ognizing our nation's past life, fostering self-reflection, and cultivating patriotism and the spirit of self-reliance."

Authoritarian-era textbooks extended the term into a more concrete register of colonial grievance and ethnic victimization:

> 1910년 이후의 일제의 식민지 지배는 우리 민족의 민족 운동을 탄압하고, 경제적 착취를 강행하며, 한국 사회와 문화를 해체시켰다.
>
> "*Japan's colonial rule after 1910 suppressed our nation's nationalist movement, enforced economic exploitation, and dismantled Korean society and culture.*" (1981)

The shift is an expansion in the range of sentence contexts in which the term appeared, spanning colonial critique, ethnic solidarity, and political legitimacy.

A similar widening is visible in *tongnip*. Postwar textbooks framed independence in concrete military-historical terms:

> 만주에서의 무장 독립 운동은 병오·정미 의병 운동이 실패한 후 이 지방으로 옮겨간 유인석, 이강년, 홍범도 휘하의 의병 부대 정착에 연원한다.
>
> "*The armed independence movement in Manchuria originated from the settlement of volunteer military units under Yu Insŏk, Yi Kangnyŏn, and Hong Pŏmdo, who moved to this region after the failure of the righteous army movement.*" (1963)

Authoritarian-era textbooks broadened the term into institutional reform discourse:

> 그는 자유 민주주의적 개혁 사상을 민중에 보급하여, 민중의 힘으로 자주 독립 국가를 수립하고자 독립 신문을 창간하고, 독립 협회를 창립하였다.
>
> "*He disseminated liberal democratic reform ideas to the people, founding the Independence Newspaper and establishing the Independence Club to build an independent state through the people's power.*" (1987)

Here too, the shift is not from one fixed meaning to another. It is an expansion in the range of sentence contexts in which independence appeared, extending from armed struggle into institutional reform, sovereignty, and state-building vocabulary.

The opposite dynamic is visible in the compressed terms. *Kongdongch'e* shows the largest contraction (-2.89), though this estimate carries more uncertainty given the small Postwar baseline. *Haebang* shows the second-largest compression (-1.98). *Sahoe* contracts substantially (-1.18), with the term narrowing from an evaluative concept toward a mobilizational

instrument in regime rhetoric. *Chŏngch'i, kukka,* and *yŏngt'o* followed a similar pattern at smaller magnitudes. The regime did not eliminate political language from textbooks. It reduced the diversity of ways in which political structures, collective life, and community could be described.

Two terms occupy modest positions within the expansion group. *T'ongil* (통일, unification) and *minjujuŭi* (민주주의, democracy) show technically positive variance shifts (+0.32 and +0.52), but their magnitudes are small compared to the other expanding terms. *T'ongil*'s usage remains largely confined to safe historical references, especially Unified Silla, together with formulaic invocations of national reunification that do not develop into substantive political discussion. The term was therefore not fully expanded but rather held in a narrow register: retained in the corpus, but constrained from developing a broader policy-oriented range. This freezing pattern identifies a third mechanism of semantic control, distinct from both expansion and compression.

Universal expansion under democratization

The Authoritarian to Democratic transition follows a markedly different pattern. Where authoritarian consolidation produced a selective split between expansion and compression, democratization produced expansion across all twelve terms. This universality is the clearest structural distinction between the two transitions. Democratization widened semantic space across the full range of identity discourse, not just the previously constrained concepts.

The magnitudes of democratic expansion vary substantially. *Kongdongch'e* records the largest point estimate in the analysis (+5.00), but its entire Postwar baseline rests on 9 sentences, five of which repeat variants of the phrase "community of destiny" (운명 공동체). That small and thematically homogeneous baseline makes the +5.00 figure an unreliable estimate of semantic range, and we flag it here so that subsequent claims about the democratic expansion do not rest on this term. Among the better-attested terms, *t'ongil* shows the largest expansion (+2.86), followed by *yŏksa* (+2.17) and *tongnip* (+2.10). *Minjujuŭi*

expands from a modest authoritarian-era increase to a much stronger democratic one. The six terms previously compressed under authoritarianism all recover: *yŏngt'o* rises to +1.34, *kukka* to +1.30, *haebang* to +1.08, *chŏngch'i* to +0.85, and *sahoe* to +0.76.

The case of *t'ongil* is particularly revealing. Under authoritarianism, the term was restricted to historical references and ritualized national formulas. A representative Authoritarian-era sentence illustrates the frozen register:

> 민족적 숙원인 국토 통일을 위하여 공산주의와 대결할 수 있는 실력 배양에 전력을 집중한다.
>
> "*Concentrate all efforts on cultivating the strength to confront communism for the territorial unification that is the nation's aspiration.*" (1973)

Unification appears here as a formulaic invocation, framed through anti-communist confrontation rather than substantive policy. Under democratization, the term expands into contemporary policy discourse:

> 정상 회담 결과 통일 문제와 남북 관계의 기본 방향을 담은 6·15 남북 공동 선언이 발표되었다.
>
> "*As a result of the summit, the June 15 Joint Declaration was announced, containing the basic direction for the unification issue and inter-Korean relations.*" (2016)

The scale of this shift confirms that unification had not been absent from authoritarian textbooks. It had been constrained. The broadening under democracy suggests that the institutional constraints of the authoritarian period, rather than a lack of relevant referents, had kept the term's usage range narrow.

Minjok (+1.22) continued to expand during democratization, though less dramatically than under authoritarianism. This moderate shift is analytically important because it shows that democratic textbooks did not construct the discourse of nation anew. The expanded semantic field of the authoritarian period persisted into the democratic corpus, where it broadened further. Under authoritarianism, *minjok* had been tied closely to ethnic nationalism, colonial suffering, and historical endurance. Democratic-era textbooks preserved those associations but extended them into the language of divided-nation politics, inter-Korean

reconciliation, and peaceful reunification, as in this 2006 textbook's framing of the July 4, 1972 Joint Statement:

> 7·4 남북 공동 성명에서 남북한은 자주 통일, 평화 통일, 민족 대단결의 3대 원칙을 내세웠다.
>
> "*In the July 4 Joint Declaration, North and South Korea put forward three principles of self-reliant reunification, peaceful reunification, and great national unity.*" (2006)

The ethnonational frame has not been abandoned. The phrase "great national unity" (민족 대단결) retains its ethnic substrate. What shifts is that democratic-era textbooks use *minjok* in the vocabulary of inter-Korean reconciliation rather than only in colonial-grievance narratives. The ethnonational field persists and widens, but does not give way to a civic-territorial alternative as in the Taiwanese case.

Other terms follow different trajectories. *Tongnip* had already expanded dramatically under authoritarianism and continued to do so under democracy, suggesting that narratives of independence remained central across both regimes, albeit in changing forms. *Yŏksa* is distinctive in showing substantial expansion across both transitions, indicating a progressive broadening of historical discourse rather than a single regime-specific rupture.

The previously compressed terms recover unevenly. Setting aside *kongdongch'e* for the reasons noted above, *yŏngt'o* expands into broader geopolitical contexts (+1.34), and *kukka* moves into comparative and international registers (+1.30). Both shifts track democratization alongside South Korea's changing position at the end of the Cold War. *Haebang* shows moderate variance expansion (+1.08), but its alignment residual of +1.91 is the largest single structural shift in the analysis, a pattern we discuss in section 5. The recovery is not uniform: *sahoe* and *haebang* recover only partially, a durability effect we examine in section 5.

Taken together, these patterns suggest that democratization worked less by imposing a new ideological order than by widening the range of permissible and meaningful contexts across the board. Where authoritarianism selectively appropriated and constrained, democracy broadly opened semantic space.

Structural reorganization as a distinct mechanism

Although variance changes dominate the analysis, the alignment residual axis identifies a second and partially independent mechanism of semantic transformation. Procrustes shifts are smaller in magnitude than variance shifts, but they capture something different: not the widening or narrowing of usage contexts, but the relocation of a term within semantic space relative to the vocabulary as a whole.

During the Postwar to Authoritarian transition, *minjok* shows the largest alignment residual shift, followed by *yŏksa* and *kungmin*. These are precisely the terms most central to nationalist legitimation. Their movement on the Procrustes axis indicates that their usage both diversified and shifted position within the conceptual field of textbook discourse. The change is not only that the regime's textbooks spoke more broadly about nation and history. The distributional relations between those concepts and the larger vocabulary of political identity also shifted.

The contrast between *tongnip* and *minjok* is especially instructive here. Both terms expand strongly on the variance axis during authoritarian consolidation, but only *minjok* shows a large Procrustes shift. *Tongnip*, by contrast, remains nearly stationary on the alignment residual axis. This indicates that independence acquired new contexts while retaining its broader structural position. *Minjok*, however, changed in two ways at once: it expanded contextually and moved geometrically. That difference is substantive. The term's distributional neighborhood shifted, placing it closer to the regime's core legitimation vocabulary. The multi-axis design is valuable precisely because it makes such differences visible.

Yŏksa offers the clearest single illustration of bidirectional structural repositioning. It records large Procrustes shifts in both directions: -0.58 during authoritarian consolidation and $+0.49$ during democratization. No other term shows Procrustes displacements of this magnitude in both transitions. The extreme sentences on the Procrustes axis make the shift legible. Under authoritarianism, history moved toward a mobilizational register. At one pole sit sentences from the *National Education Charter* ("길이 후손에 물려줄 영광된 통일 조국의

앞날을 내다보며…새 역사를 창조하자," "Let us create new history"), together with accounts of scholarly resistance to Japanese historical distortion. At the other sit origin myths, textual traditions, and pedagogical study questions. Under democracy, the term moved again, this time toward participatory and inquiry-based uses: students using prior historical knowledge to evaluate events, and social history topics such as the buying and selling of *yangban* status. The *yŏksa* case shows that structural repositioning can recur across transitions rather than being tied to a single regime type, though the generality of that pattern would require further cases to establish.

During the Authoritarian to Democratic transition, *haebang* shows by far the largest Procrustes shift (+1.91), the only alignment residual in the analysis that reaches a magnitude comparable to the variance axis. This shift reflects the term's polysemy. As shown in Appendix G of the Supplementary Information, the contrastive axes for *haebang* separate senses of the word rather than political framings of the same event. Under authoritarianism, the term's secondary usage was confined to premodern slave emancipation, framed as benevolent royal policy ("양민으로서 억울하게 노비가 된 자들을 해방시켜," "emancipating those unjustly enslaved," 1981). Under democracy, this register shifted toward explicitly political social-movement usage:

> 독립 운동계는 민족 해방을 부르짖는 민족주의 계열과 계급 해방을 목표로 하는 사회주의 세력으로 양분되었다.
>
> "*The independence movement split into a nationalist faction calling for national liberation and a socialist faction aiming for class liberation.*" (2007)

The Procrustes shift captures this rotation as a geometric relocation rather than simple contextual broadening. *Yŏksa*, *kungmin*, and *minjok* also show substantial Procrustes shifts in this transition, though at smaller magnitudes. *Minjok* remains among the terms most clearly reorganized across both transitions, consistent with its central role in identity discourse in both regimes. By contrast, *t'ongil* again shows the opposite pattern: a very large variance shift with almost no Procrustes displacement. As in the earlier case of *tongnip*, the term expands dramatically without relocating structurally.

These results confirm that contextual expansion and structural reorganization are related but distinct processes. Some concepts broaden while remaining geometrically stable, others broaden and relocate at the same time, and a few undergo repeated structural repositioning across successive transitions. *Haebang* illustrates a distinct possibility: moderate variance expansion paired with large-scale structural reorganization, where the driving force is the activation of previously dormant word senses rather than political reframing. Semantic change in educational discourse is therefore not one-dimensional.

Stability and incomplete recovery

Two terms are especially useful for clarifying the limits of regime-driven semantic change: *chŏngch'i* (정치, politics) and *sahoe* (사회, society). At the level of mean absolute change, *chŏngch'i* is among the most stable terms in the analysis. This does not mean that its usage remained unchanged: the discriminative axis still detects clear period-specific framing. What distinguishes politics is that its semantic range does not undergo the large expansions or contractions visible in more ideologically charged concepts. It appears to function as a relatively stable descriptive category across regime types.

Sahoe, however, follows a very different trajectory. Its overall mean absolute shift is only moderate, but this aggregate masks a dramatic contraction under authoritarianism followed by an incomplete recovery under democracy. The extreme sentences illustrate what the compression looks like in practice. Postwar textbooks used *sahoe* as a normative concept open to evaluation:

> 이런 우애의 정신이 사회에 가득 찰 때, 그 사회는 민주적이라 말할 수 있다.
> "*When the spirit of fraternity fills society, that society can be called democratic.*" (1954)

A textbook published at the start of Park Chung-hee's Yushin regime narrows the term into a mobilizational register tied directly to regime goals:

> 이제 우리는, 국민의 단결된 힘을 바탕으로 복된 사회를 이룩하고, 한국적 민주주의의 기반을 튼튼하게 하기 위한 노력을 힘차게 펴게 되었다.

> "*Now we have come to strive vigorously to build a blessed society on the basis of the united strength of the people and to strengthen the foundation of Korean-style democracy.*" (1973)

The phrase *han'gukchŏk minjujuŭi* ("Korean-style democracy") is Park's signature Yushin vocabulary, used to justify the 1972 October Restoration. In the Postwar sentence, society is a concept open to evaluation: whether it is democratic depends on the values that fill it. In the Yushin-era sentence, society is something to be "built" through national unity in service of a regime-specific political form. The term shifts from an analytical category to an instrumental one. Democratization reopened some of that lost range, but not all of it. The recovery reaches only about two thirds of the preceding contraction (+0.76 against −1.18). *Haebang* follows a similar pattern, recovering roughly half of its lost variance (+1.08 against −1.98). Of the six compressed terms, these two show incomplete recovery, while the other four recover fully or overshoot (though *kongdongch'e*'s large overshoot rests on only 9 Postwar sentences). This pattern suggests that semantic narrowing imposed by authoritarian educational discourse may persist even after the political conditions that produced it have changed.

Summary of findings

Tables 6 and 7 summarize the trajectory of each term across the two post-liberation transitions, grouped by thematic cluster.

Five findings follow from the analysis. First, variance changes dominate both post-liberation transitions. Educational discourse responded to regime change primarily through the expansion, contraction, or containment of usage contexts rather than through wholesale replacement of core meanings. Second, authoritarian consolidation produced selective change: six concepts tied to national identity and historical legitimation expanded, while six concepts associated with political and social analysis, community, and liberation compressed. Third, democratization produced expansion across all twelve terms, indicating a

Table 6: Semantic trajectory profiles for the ethnonational and historical terms. The dominant pattern column identifies the primary mechanism of change across the two post-liberation transitions.

Term	Dominant pattern	Trajectory
Nation (민족)	Expansion plus structural repositioning	Expanded under authoritarianism (+1.74) through ethnic nationalism and colonial grievance, while also undergoing the largest structural shift in the transition. Continued moderate expansion under democracy (+1.22), extending the semantic field into inter-Korean relations discourse.
Independence (독립)	Variance expansion	Massive expansion under authoritarianism (+2.83) through appropriation of independence narratives for state legitimation. Continued expansion under democracy (+2.10).
History (역사)	Progressive expansion with structural repositioning	Relatively balanced variance expansion across both transitions (+1.49, +2.17). Also shows the largest bidirectional Procrustes shifts (−0.58, +0.49), indicating repeated structural reorganization.
Territory (영토)	Mild compression, then expansion	Slight compression under authoritarianism (−0.18). Expanded under democracy (+1.34) into broader geopolitical contexts.
Liberation (해방)	Compression, then polysemy rotation	Compressed under authoritarianism (−1.98). Moderate variance expansion under democracy (+1.08) with massive structural repositioning (+1.91) as premodern and social-movement senses displaced the fixed commemorative framing.
Society (사회)	Compression, incomplete recovery	Substantial compression under authoritarianism (−1.18) as the term narrowed from open democratic evaluation toward regime-directed mobilizational use. Partial recovery under democracy (+0.76), suggesting durable effects of authoritarian standardization.

Table 7: Semantic trajectory profiles for the civic and political terms. The dominant pattern column identifies the primary mechanism of change across the two post-liberation transitions.

Term	Dominant pattern	Trajectory
State (국가)	Compression, then internationalization	Compressed under authoritarianism (−0.85). Expanded under democracy (+1.30) into broader geopolitical and comparative contexts.
Citizens (국민)	Institutionalization	Expanded through authoritarian institutionalization (+1.59) around the National Education Charter. Continued expansion under democracy (+1.48).
Democracy (민주주의)	Modest expansion, then acceleration	Moderate expansion under authoritarianism (+0.52). Stronger expansion under democracy (+1.58).
Politics (정치)	Stable anchor	Among the smallest overall shifts of any term. Maintains a relatively stable semantic range across both transitions.
Unification (통일)	Freezing, then release	Frozen in historical reference under authoritarianism (+0.32) despite continued frequency. Dramatic expansion under democracy (+2.86) into contemporary policy discourse.
Community (공동체)	Unreliable outlier	Nominally largest compression (−2.89) and expansion (+5.00), but the Postwar baseline consists of only 9 sentences, five of which repeat "community of destiny" (운명 공동체). Estimates are too fragile to support substantive interpretation.

broad opening of semantic space rather than selective release (with the caveat that *kongdongch'e*'s extreme values rest on a 9-sentence baseline and should be set aside in assessing the universality claim). Fourth, individual terms followed distinct trajectories depending on their political salience, including appropriation, freezing, progressive expansion, polysemy rotation, and incomplete recovery. *Minjok* is especially revealing here: it combines semantic expansion with structural repositioning, showing how regime change could reorganize the conceptual center of identity discourse without replacing the term itself. Fifth, authoritarian compression was not fully reversible. The two most analytically charged compressed terms, *sahoe* and *haebang*, recovered only roughly two thirds and half of their lost semantic range under democracy.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

How do the language and ideas defining a national identity in state-sanctioned educational material vary across regime types? Evidence from 67 Korean history textbooks across five political regimes points to two distinct mechanisms rather than a simple authoritarian-democratic dichotomy. Authoritarian schooling did not narrow the language of national identity uniformly. It widened the meanings of some concepts, especially *nation*, *independence*, and *citizens*, around ethnic belonging and historical grievance, while holding others, especially *community*, *society*, and *politics*, to a narrower set of rote, formulaic uses. Democratization lifted those constraints broadly. All twelve identity terms recover or expand, returning room for plural and contested meanings rather than installing a new official narrative. The national vocabulary itself was largely shared across regimes. What changed was what the words in that vocabulary were permitted to mean.

Theoretical implications

The central finding, that authoritarian schooling worked unevenly while democratization opened the vocabulary across the board, speaks directly to the relationship between political institutions and national narrative. The authoritarian regime did not treat the national vocabulary evenly. It widened the meanings of concepts useful for historical legitimation and disciplined citizenship, and it held concepts that opened onto broader political or social analysis to a narrow set of rote, formulaic uses. *Independence*, *nation*, and *citizens* were allowed to mean more because their wider meanings helped authorize the regime. *Society*, *politics*, *state*, *community*, *liberation*, and *territory* were held to standardized formulations because broader meanings were harder to control. This pattern of selective appropriation is consistent with Tetteh and Edgell's (2026) finding that educational indoctrination in autocracies serves regime consolidation.

Democratization, by contrast, operated as a broad constraint-lifter on ideas rather than total restructuring. All twelve terms expanded without exception. The mean absolute alignment residual rose from 0.31 to 0.40, driven largely by a single term: *haebang*, whose polysemy rotation produced the largest structural shift in the analysis (+1.91). Most terms show only modest structural repositioning under democracy, and the median alignment residual remains small, indicating that democratization opened usage contexts without wholesale geometric reorganization for most of the vocabulary. Individual terms, however, tell a more nuanced story: *yŏksa* underwent substantial repositioning in both transitions, and *haebang*'s geometric relocation shows that structural reorganization can also be driven by the activation of dormant word senses rather than by political reframing alone. This finding complicates Snyder (2000)'s argument that democratization can intensify nationalist mobilization. In the Korean textbook case, democratization inherited and extended the ethnonationalist vocabulary that authoritarianism had expanded and consolidated. *Minjok* continued to grow in semantic range, and independence discourse remained expansive. But this occurred alongside the recovery of compressed political and social terminology and the shift of core identity

concepts like unification into contemporary policy discourse. The contrast with Taiwan is instructive. Curriculum reform and democratic opening displaced the ethnonationalist Chinese frame in favor of a civic-territorial Taiwanese identity (Chen et al., 2023; Ho, 2022). South Korean textbooks did not abandon ethnonationalism under democracy; they maintained it within a widened discursive field.

Jo (2025)'s framework of "storytelling elites" helps explain the mechanism. Under the *kukchŏngje* system, NIKH functioned as the sole storytelling elite institution, and the textbook became the regime's direct speech act. The semantic selectivity we observe fits that arrangement. After liberalization, the shift to certification and private publishing multiplied the actors who could shape textbook language. The universal expansion of the democratic era reflects the aggregate effect of many authors working within a broader range of permissible interpretive frameworks. Jo's finding that South Korean storytelling elites entrenched the ethnonationalist narrative is consistent with our observation that *minjok* discourse continued to expand under democracy. Our analysis adds that this entrenchment occurred alongside the recovery and expansion of concepts such as society, politics, state, democracy, and unification that the authoritarian narrative had constrained.

The finding that authoritarian compression was not fully reversible carries implications for how we understand the durability of state interventions in educational discourse. Darden and Grzymala-Busse (2006) show that the national identity instilled by the first regime to achieve mass schooling persists across subsequent regime changes. Our results suggest a complementary mechanism: even when the regime changes, the *narrowing* of conceptual vocabulary that an authoritarian regime imposed can outlast the regime itself. Of the six terms compressed under authoritarianism, *sahoe* and *haebang*, the two most analytically charged, recovered only about two thirds and half of their lost semantic range. The other four recovered fully or overshot. The incomplete recovery of analytical vocabulary left marks on educational discourse that three decades of democratic governance did not erase. If Billig's (1995) banal nationalism operates through the routine, unremarked reproduction of national

categories, then the formulaic residue of authoritarian standardization may constitute a form of banal constraint: a narrowing of the conceptual tools available for critical social analysis that persists precisely because it is unremarkable.

These findings also speak to the literature on education and boundary-making. Wimmer (2013) argues that national identity depends on symbolic boundaries that define who belongs. Our results show that regime transitions changed the vocabulary available for drawing those boundaries. Under authoritarianism, textbook language was sharpened for ethnic-national boundary marking and blunted for political-structural analysis. Under democracy, the vocabulary widened in every direction. Authors had more conceptual room to describe political institutions, society, community, and unification without abandoning ethnonational language. Related survey-experimental work involving one of the present authors finds that identity conformity pressures are substantially stronger in South Korea, where state-authored textbook traditions remained more uniform for longer (Denney et al., 2026).

What regime type establishes, modulates, and pluralizes

Across the three post-liberation regimes, the evidence fits a three-phase reading of how textbook national identity varies. The first phase is establishment. A stable core vocabulary of Korean nationhood is in place across all three periods: *minjok*, *kukka*, *kungmin*, *tongnip*, *t'ongil*, and *yŏngt'o* appear in Postwar, Authoritarian, and Democratic textbooks alike, at high frequencies and in recurring contexts. What counts as identity vocabulary is therefore not an invention of authoritarianism. Once Japanese imperial historiography was displaced at liberation, any postcolonial state educating its citizens in national history needed this set of terms, and successor regimes inherited it. The regime-invariance of the core layer is what makes the later variations legible as variations rather than as foundational ruptures.

The second phase is modulation. It captures what authoritarian textbooks did with the inherited vocabulary. Under Yushin and the Chun/Roh transition, the meanings around concepts tied to state legitimation broaden, while concepts that open onto political or so-

cial analysis are held to a thinner register. *Minjok*, *tongnip*, and *kungmin* take on a wider range of meanings through ethnic grievance, anti-colonial narrative, and disciplined citizenship, and the analysis also records their repositioning within the broader vocabulary. *Sahoe*, *kongdongch'e*, and *haebang* are pulled toward formulaic or commemorative usage. Regime-specific narrowing is quantitatively as much as qualitatively visible. Identity language becomes more uniform, more saturated with state-serving framing, and more tightly bound to a single ideological frame. This is the layer in which the centralized *kukchŏngje* system leaves its clearest mark on the corpus.

The third phase is pluralization. It describes what the corpus shows once central control is lifted. Democratic-era textbooks do not abandon the national vocabulary. All twelve identity terms take on a wider range of meanings, and ethnonational concepts continue to grow. What changes is the tightness of the bond between them. Democratization widens the range of permissible meanings for every term, releases *t'ongil* from its historicized frame into contemporary policy discourse, and reopens *sahoe* and *kongdongch'e* as active analytical categories, though unevenly. The vocabulary becomes messier: multi-vocal rather than single-voiced, less tightly gathered into a single ideological frame. Democracy does not de-nationalize the textbook. It de-solidifies it. The regime-invariant core persists, but the surrounding language becomes more plural.

The hard test

We framed *kuksa* as a hard test of whether political institutions shape the grand narrative. Secondary literature characterizes national history as a conservative domain of the Korean curriculum, a discursive space less likely to change than social studies or ethics (Ahn, 2012; Moon, 2011). We have not tested that claim comparatively, and a cross-domain analysis remains a priority for future work. On the expectation that *kuksa* is resistant to change, the findings are clear. Variance shifts of 1.37 (authoritarian) and 1.81 (democratic) in standard deviation units, measured in the most conservative site of state-directed narra-

tive production, show that political institutions reached into the core vocabulary of national self-understanding. The authoritarian regime appropriated independence discourse for state legitimation, froze unification in safe historical reference, and compressed society into formulaic headings. The democratic transition released frozen concepts, recovered compressed ones, and expanded semantic range across the board. These are changes in the language through which millions of students were taught to understand the nation.

Methodological contribution

The analysis also contributes to the methodological repertoire for computational text analysis in the humanities and social sciences. The LLM-based term discovery pipeline offers a middle path between researcher-imposed keyword lists, which risk projecting the analyst's conceptual frame onto the corpus, and fully unsupervised topic models, which may miss domain-specific concepts that do not neatly cluster in latent topic space. The pipeline is targeted: it asks the model to extract concepts relevant to a specific analytical category rather than to discover latent themes. But it is also corpus-driven, in that the terms emerge from the texts rather than from the researcher's prior expectations.

The robustness validation against BERTopic and LDA demonstrates both the value and the necessity of multi-method comparison. BERTopic recovered all 12 LLM-discovered terms, confirming that they correspond to genuine clusters in the corpus's embedding space. LDA recovered 7 of 12, missing terms that were either too ubiquitous (state, history) or too sparse (community) for document-level bag-of-words modeling to isolate. The LLM pipeline captured concepts across this frequency spectrum because it operates on local text windows and evaluates semantic relevance rather than statistical distinctiveness. At the same time, the convergence across methods (every LLM-discovered term was recovered by at least one conventional approach) provides confidence that the analytical vocabulary is grounded in the corpus rather than generated by the extraction process. Neither BERTopic nor LDA would have produced the same 12-term list independently, but together they confirm that the LLM

output is not an artifact.

This multi-method validation framework is generalizable. Any study using LLMs for concept extraction from a specialized corpus faces the question of whether the output reflects corpus structure or model priors. Running conventional topic models as independent checks, and interpreting both the agreements and the disagreements, provides a principled answer. The disagreements are as informative as the agreements: the five terms that LDA missed tell us something about the limits of bag-of-words modeling for identity-relevant vocabulary, just as the complete BERTopic recovery tells us something about the alignment between LLM extraction and embedding-based clustering.

Limitations

Several limitations bear on the interpretation of these findings. First, our corpus contains only South Korean textbooks. A matched analysis of North Korean history or morals textbooks would help separate regime-type effects from features specific to South Korea's path through anti-colonial state formation, authoritarian developmentalism, and democratic liberalization. Won and Huntington (2021) document the broad divergence of North and South Korean identity narratives, but the kind of corpus-wide semantic analysis presented here has not yet been done on North Korean materials. Second, the analysis measures changes in textbook language, not reader reception. We can track how the semantic contexts of identity terms changed, but not how students interpreted those changes or how strongly textbooks shaped their views. Third, sentence embeddings capture distributional semantics, the company a term keeps, rather than meaning in a stronger philosophical sense. A shift on the contrastive variance axis shows that a term appeared in a wider or narrower range of contexts; it does not by itself tell us how a student or teacher would paraphrase that term. Fourth, textbooks are only one part of classroom practice. They are the most standardized part, which is why they are analytically valuable, but teachers still mediate them. Fifth, the five-period periodization necessarily compresses internal variation. The authoritarian period

spans Yushin, Chun, and early Roh; the democratic period spans two decades of curricular and political change. A finer-grained design would require a larger corpus.

Future directions

Several extensions would strengthen the argument. A cross-system comparison with North Korean textbooks would test whether selective appropriation is a general feature of centralized textbook production or a feature of South Korea's particular authoritarian trajectory. A cross-domain comparison within South Korea, especially between *kuksa* and social studies, would test the hard-test claim directly: if social studies shows earlier or larger semantic shifts, then national history really was the conservative edge case we treat it as. Reader-reception work would answer a different question altogether, namely whether the semantic shifts documented here altered how students understood nationhood, citizenship, and unification. The methodological framework also travels. Comparable textbook corpora from Taiwan, Japan, or other post-authoritarian settings would let us test whether the split we find here, selective compression under centralized authorship and broader expansion under democratization, appears elsewhere.

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